

concerns of the common man can take a backseat. **MAHENDRA KALANTRI**, via www.indiatoday.in

The ever-increasing food price inflation is not only hurting the common man, it is also creating economic instability which may even lead to political disruption. How can prices fall when farmers, brokers, wholesalers and retailers want to sell their products at a higher price and create artificial supply bottlenecks in a desperate pursuit to make money at the expense of the *aam aadmi* who has emerged severely battered? The real tragedy is that he doesn't even know who to complain to. **VITULL K. GUPTA, Bathinda**

Last Rights

Twenty five years after deserting him, George Fernandes's family has suddenly resurfaced when he is fighting for his survival ("By George, It's War", February 8). Jaya Jaitley has sincerely been with him all these years. The proceeds from selling his property must be appropriated exactly according to the leader's wishes. **V.K. TANGRI, Dehradun**

Padma of Discord

The selection system for Padma awards is bizarre ("A World of Honour", February 8). Is it practical that an awards committee

comprising 10 members from different fields choose about 130 names from 1,200 recommendations in a meeting of a few hours, and that too in three different variants? The guidelines of the K.R. Narayanan Committee are flouted when there is no last date of recommendation from either the President, vice-president, prime minister or the home minister. This leads to last-minute inclusion of

home but put under house arrest. If this drastic change is not possible, then jails with women prisoners having kids should be provided with crèche facilities. Let us have a jail system with a humane face. **DBN MURTHY, Bangalore**

Reviving Allahabad

Both the first family of the Congress and that of Bollywood have their roots in Allahabad ("Wasting



SUBIR HALDER/www.indiatodayimages.com

Though a first-time MP, Shashi Tharoor has been parachuted to a ministerial berth. Since then he has trod on many toes and ruffled wrong feathers. He's rightly called the Twitter Minister.

P.K. GUPTA, via www.indiatoday.in

names with the formality of endorsement by the committee members coming even telephonically. **S.C. AGRAWAL, Delhi**

No Kidding

It is a shame that women with little children have to languish in prison ("Children of Lesser Gods", February 1). There should be some change in the existing laws which ensure that such women are sent

Away", January 25). They should come forward to lead the revival of this great city. For inspiration, they can visit Surat, a city that was probably worse off than Allahabad till 1995. It is now one of the cleanest cities of India. Allahabad should be declared a heritage city and efficient officials should be posted for a fixed tenure for its revival. **JITENDRA DESAI, Surat**

30
YEARS
AGO IN
INDIA
TODAY

APRIL 16-30, 1980

Dangerous Stalemate

On April 12, as the air force's MI-3 helicopter carrying Mrs Gandhi droned above Gauhati in strife-torn Assam, a police officer leaned out of his jeep and told fellow cops: "Look, that's *bordoi chila* going." The words mean the mercurial fairy who augurs the *bihu* (Assamese New Year) festivities with a gentle shower but rides out of the Brahmaputra valley on a mighty cyclone, leaving a trail of devastation. The prime minister's abortive nine-hour visit to the state and adjoining Meghalaya, instead of assuaging the six-month-long demonstration rocking Assam left the air heavy with the apprehension of a spring cyclone. A crackdown on oil-pipeline picketers? An ordinance followed by large scale detention of the demonstrators? "The choice of weapon is entirely hers," snapped an enraged student leader as reports reached Gauhati that the talks had broken down at the state Guest House (named Indira Bhavan during the Emergency), on top of the picturesque Jawahar-nagar hill **by Sumit Mitra**



MRS GANDHI AND ZAIL SINGH ARRIVING AT GAUHATI

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